

# Budget Bridge

## User Guide

Personal finance tracking, budgeting insights, and AI assistance



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Brain Duong

Deming Lei

Jacob Biddinger

Kevin Zhang

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# 1. Introduction

Budget Bridge is a web-based personal finance application for recording income, tracking spending, reviewing transaction history, and understanding financial patterns over time. The application combines a clean dashboard with categorized transaction tables, visual charts, profile settings, and an AI-powered assistant.

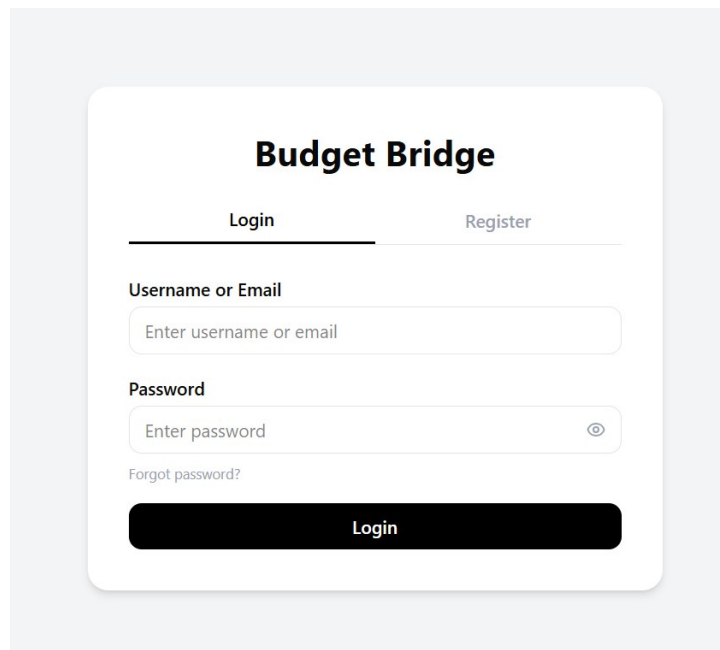
With Budget Bridge, you can:

- Register and log in with a user account.
- View total balance, monthly income, monthly spending, and recent activity from the Dashboard.
- Add expense transactions with dates, categories, amounts, and optional descriptions.
- Add income transactions with standard or custom categories.
- Search, filter, sort, and delete transactions.
- Review all income and expense activity in a single History page.
- Edit profile information, change password, and switch between light mode and dark mode.
- Ask the AI Budget Bridge Assistant for budget recommendations, unusual transaction checks, and finance summaries.

**Note: The screenshots in this guide show sample demo data. Actual values, categories, and transaction dates will depend on the data in your own account.**

## 2. Launching the Application

After the frontend and backend are running, open the Budget Bridge web application in your browser. The first screen is the authentication page. From here, you can either log in or switch to the registration tab.



*Figure 1. Budget Bridge login screen.*

### 3. Using the Main Menu

After logging in, Budget Bridge displays a persistent left sidebar. The sidebar is the main navigation menu for the application.

| Menu Item | Purpose                                                                                       |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dashboard | View summary cards, income vs. expenses trend, category charts, and recent transactions.      |
| Spending  | Add, review, search, filter, sort, and delete expense records.                                |
| Income    | Add, review, search, filter, sort, and delete income records.                                 |
| History   | View all income and expense transactions together; filter by type; undo recent deletions.     |
| Profile   | View or edit account information, send a password reset email, and switch light or dark mode. |
| Logout    | End the current session and return to the login screen.                                       |

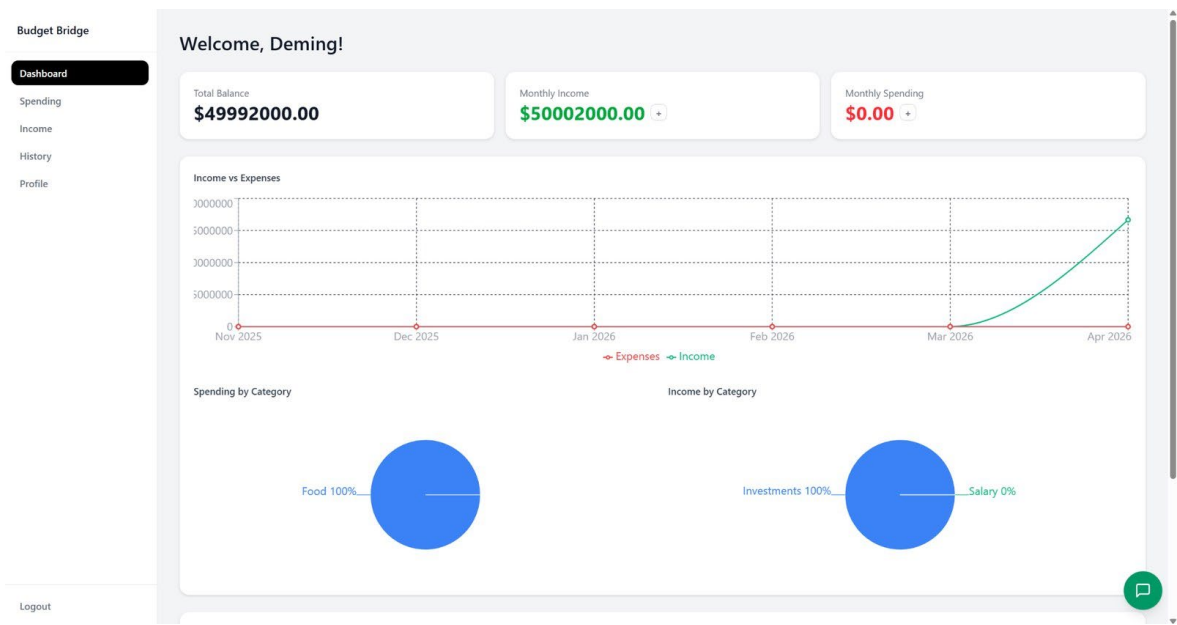


Figure 2. Dashboard layout with the sidebar menu.

## 4. Creating an Account

Use the Register tab to create a new Budget Bridge account. Registration requires a username, email address, password, and password confirmation.

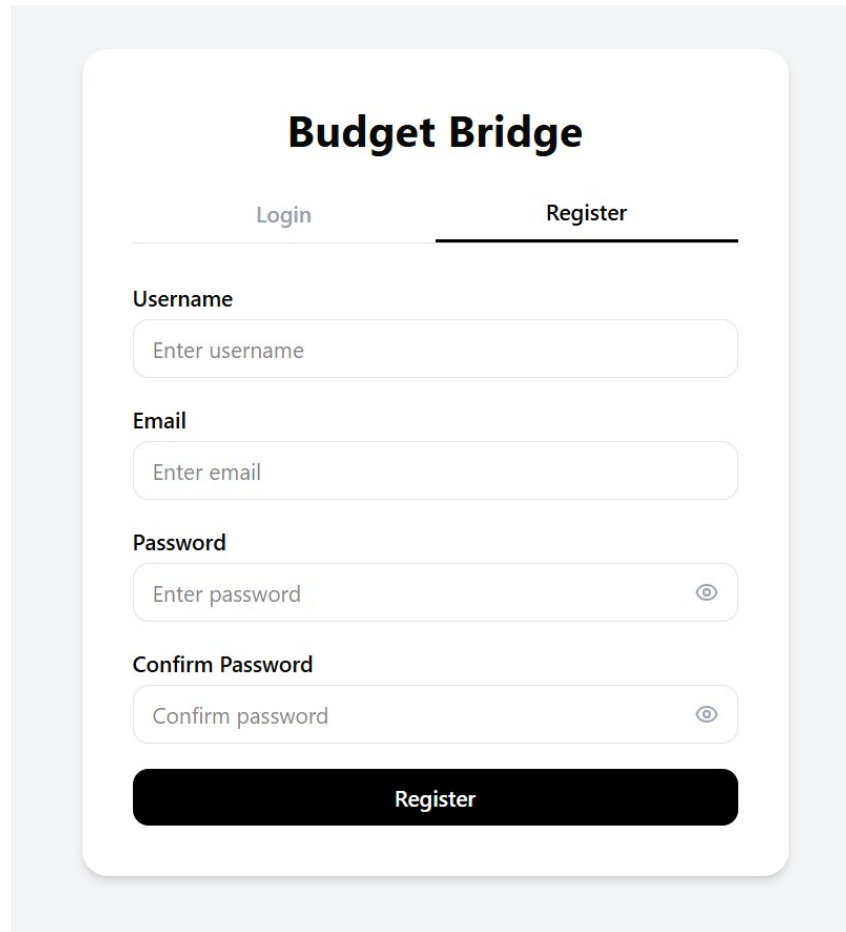
The image shows a registration form for 'Budget Bridge'. At the top, the title 'Budget Bridge' is centered. Below it are two tabs: 'Login' and 'Register', with 'Register' being the active tab. The form contains four input fields: 'Username' with placeholder text 'Enter username', 'Email' with placeholder text 'Enter email', 'Password' with placeholder text 'Enter password' and a toggle icon, and 'Confirm Password' with placeholder text 'Confirm password' and a toggle icon. At the bottom is a large black button labeled 'Register'.

Figure 3. Registration screen.

### 4.1 Registration Steps

1. Select the Register tab on the authentication card.
2. Enter a username.
3. Enter a valid email address.
4. Enter a password.
5. Enter the same password in Confirm Password.
6. Select Register.

### 4.2 Password Rules

For security, passwords must meet these rules:

- Password must be at least 8 characters and include at least one number, one lowercase letter, and one special character.

## 5. Logging In

Use the Login tab to access your Budget Bridge account. You can enter either your username or email address.

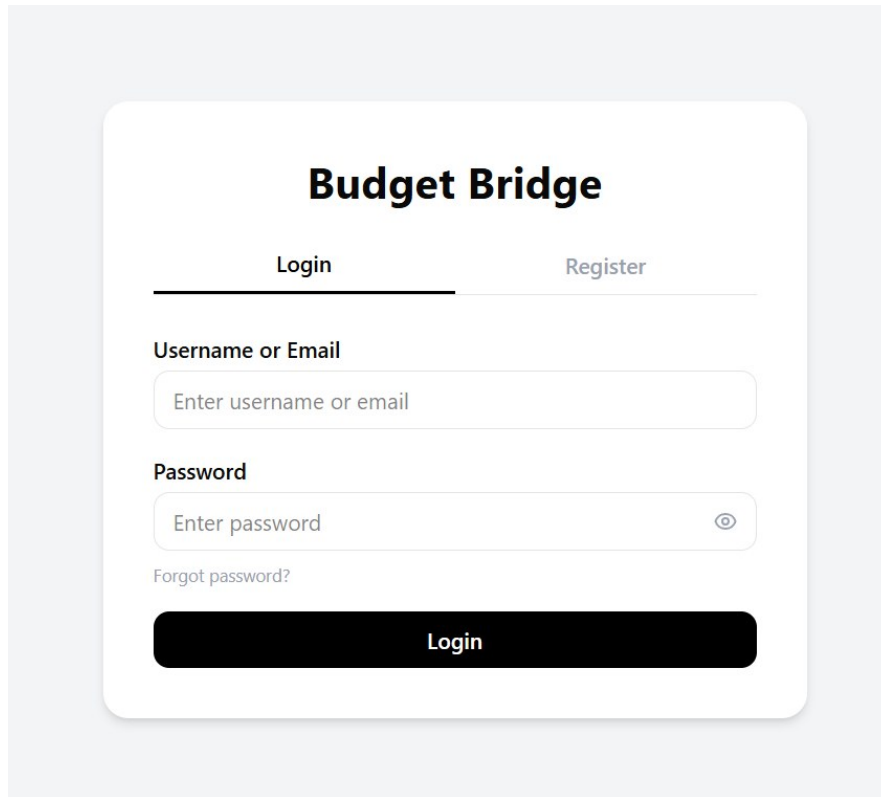
The image shows a login interface for 'Budget Bridge'. At the top, the title 'Budget Bridge' is centered. Below it are two tabs: 'Login' (which is active and underlined) and 'Register'. The 'Login' section contains a label 'Username or Email' above a text input field with the placeholder 'Enter username or email'. Below this is a label 'Password' above a password input field with the placeholder 'Enter password' and an eye icon for toggling visibility. Under the password field is a link 'Forgot password?'. At the bottom of the form is a large black button with the text 'Login' in white.

Figure 4. Login screen with username/email and password fields.

### 5.1 Login Steps

1. Select the Login tab.
2. Enter your username or email address.
3. Enter your password.
4. Select Login.

### 5.2 Forgot Password

If you cannot remember your password, select *Forgot password* on the login form. Enter your email address, then follow the reset link sent to your inbox. The reset page asks for a new password and confirmation.

## 6. Using the Dashboard

The Dashboard is the main overview page. It gives a quick snapshot of your account balance, income, expenses, charts, and recent activity.

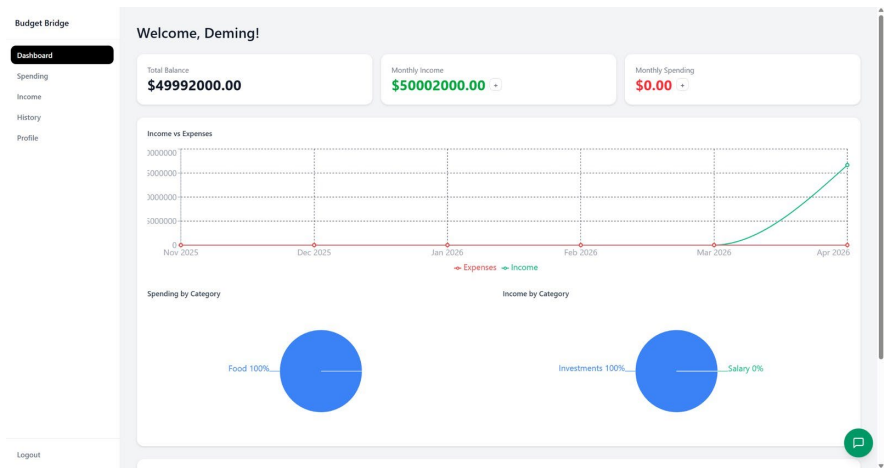


Figure 5. Dashboard overview.

### 6.1 Summary

|                  | Shows                                     | Action                                        |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Total Balance    | Income minus expenses across the account. | Review the overall account status.            |
| Monthly Income   | Income recorded for the current month.    | Use the plus button to open the income form.  |
| Monthly Spending | Expenses recorded for the current month.  | Use the plus button to open the expense form. |

### 6.2 Charts

- Income vs Expenses: line chart comparing monthly income and expense trends.
- Spending by Category: pie chart showing expense distribution across categories.
- Income by Category: pie chart showing income distribution across categories.

### 6.3 Recent Transactions

The Recent Transactions table displays the newest income and expense records together. You can search by description or category, filter by category, and sort by column headers.

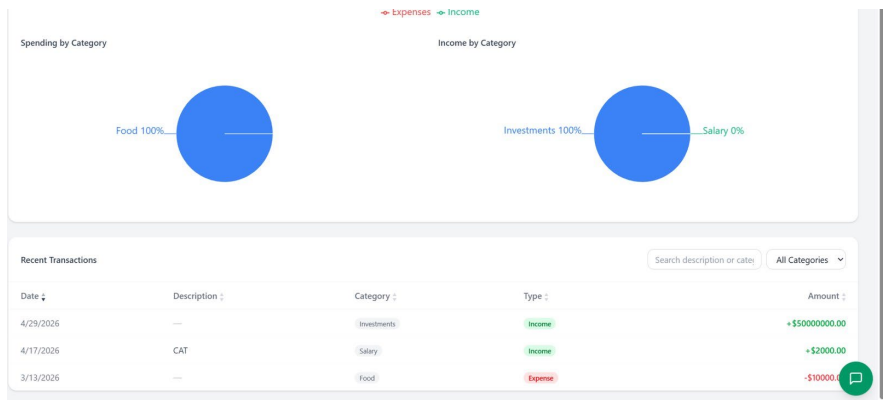


Figure 6. Recent transactions table and category charts.

## 7. Adding and Managing Expenses

The Spending page records money leaving your account. Use it for purchases, bills, fees, and other expenses.

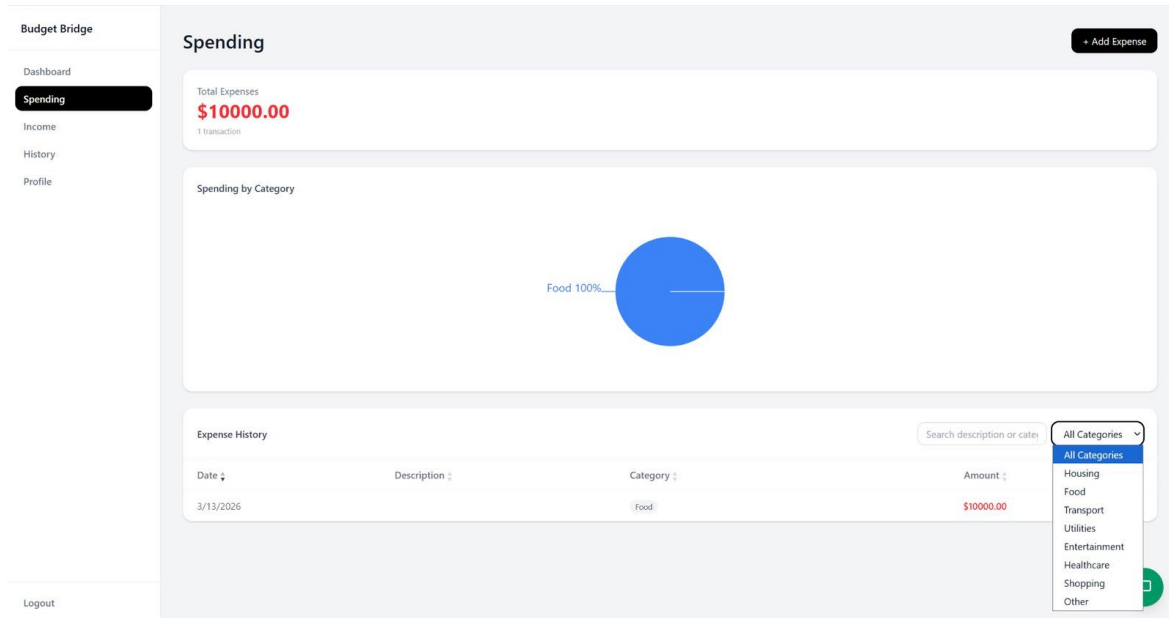


Figure 7. Spending page summary, chart, and expense history.

### 7.1 Add an Expense

1. Open the Spending page from the sidebar.
2. Select + Add Expense.
3. Choose the expense date.
4. Select an existing category such as Housing, Food, Transport, Utilities, Entertainment, Healthcare, Shopping, or Other.
5. Enter the amount.
6. Optionally enter a description.
7. Select Add Expense to save the transaction, or Cancel to discard it.

**Budget Bridge**

- Dashboard
- Spending**
- Income
- History
- Profile

**Spending** + Add Expense

**New Expense**

Date: 04/28/2026

Category: Select category

Amount (\$): 0.00

Description (optional): Enter description

Add Expense Cancel Add

**Total Expenses:**  
**\$10000.00**  
Transaction

**Spending by Category**

Food 100%

**Expense History** Search description or cate All Categories

| Date      | Description | Category | Amount     |
|-----------|-------------|----------|------------|
| 3/13/2026 |             | Food     | \$10000.00 |

[Logout](#) +

Figure 8. New Expense form.

## 7.2 Add a Custom Expense Category

1. Open the expense form.
2. Type a new category name in the Add custom category field.
3. Select Add.
4. Select the new category from the category list.

## 7.3 Review Expense History

- Total Expenses updates based on the currently filtered data.
- Spending by Category updates based on the visible expense records.
- The Expense History table supports searching, category filtering, sorting, and deleting.

**Note: Deleting an expense removes it from the Spending page and updates the Dashboard and History summaries.**

## 8. Adding and Managing Income

The Income page records money entering your account. Use it for salary, freelance payments, investments, rental income, and other sources.

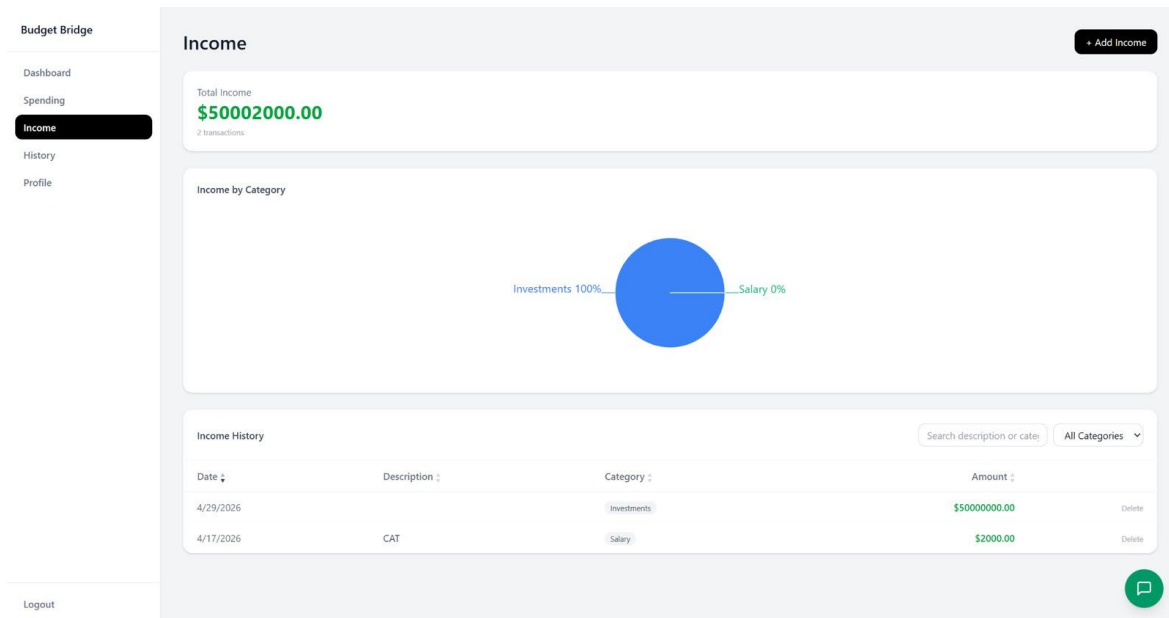


Figure 9. Income page summary, chart, and income history.

### 8.1 Add Income

1. Open the Income page from the sidebar.
2. Select + Add Income.
3. Choose the income date.
4. Select an existing category such as Salary, Freelance, Investments, Rental, or Other.
5. Enter the amount.
6. Optionally enter a description.
7. Select Add Income to save the transaction, or Cancel to discard it.

**Budget Bridge**

- Dashboard
- Spending
- Income**
- History
- Profile

**Income** + Add Income

**New Income**

Date: 04/28/2026

Amount (\$): 0.00

Add Income Cancel

**Category**

Select category

Add custom category Add

Description (optional):

Enter description

**Total Income**

**\$5000200.00**

Transactions

**Income by Category**

Investments 100% Salary 0%

**Income History**

Search description or cate All Categories

| Date      | Description | Category    | Amount       |
|-----------|-------------|-------------|--------------|
| 4/29/2026 | CAT         | Investments | \$5000000.00 |
| 4/17/2026 | CAT         | Salary      | \$2000.00    |

Logout Dashboard Income History Profile Logout

Figure 10. New Income form.

## 8.2 Add a Custom Income Category

1. Open the income form.
2. Type the new category name in the Add custom category field.
3. Select Add.
4. Select the new category from the category list.

## 8.3 Review Income History

- Total Income updates based on the currently filtered data.
- Income by Category updates based on visible income records.
- The Income History table supports searching, category filtering, sorting, and deleting.

# 9. Viewing Transaction History

The History page combines income and expense transactions into a single table. It is useful for auditing records, comparing totals, and recovering from recent accidental deletions.

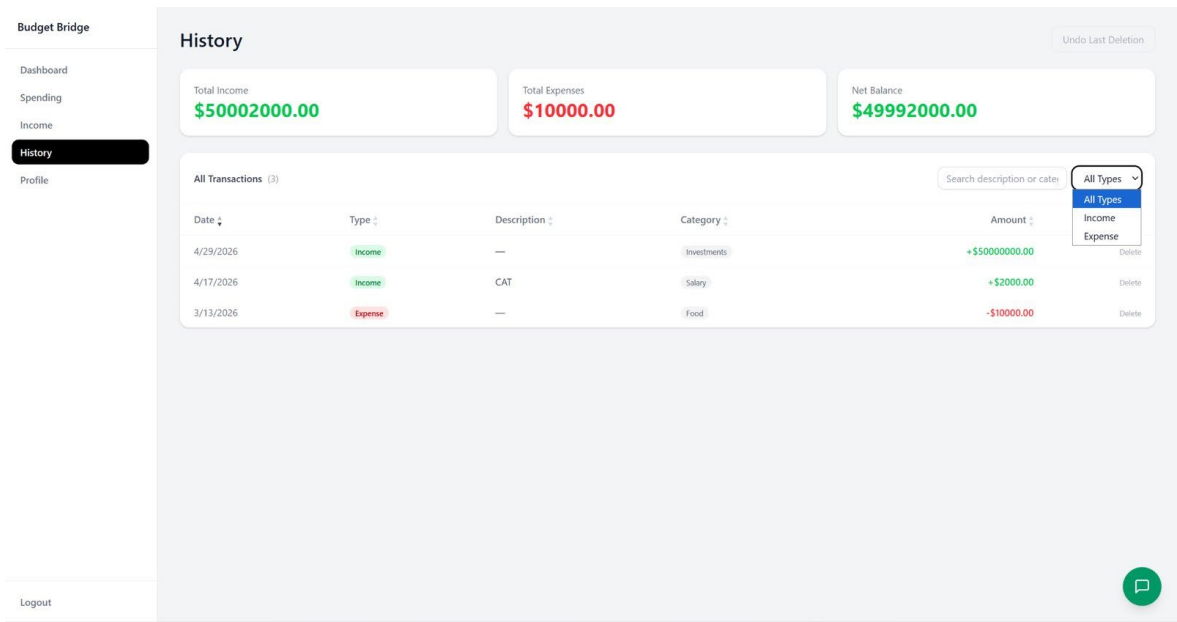


Figure 11. History page with total income, total expenses, net balance, and all transactions.

## 9.1 Summary

|                | Meaning                            |
|----------------|------------------------------------|
| Total Income   | Sum of all income transactions.    |
| Total Expenses | Sum of all expense transactions.   |
| Net Balance    | Total income minus total expenses. |

## 9.2 Filter and Search

- Use the search field to find records by description or category.
- Use the type filter to show All Types, Income, or Expense.
- Select a table header to sort by Date, Type, Description, Category, or Amount.

## 9.3 Delete and Undo

1. Select Delete on the transaction row to remove a record.
2. Use Undo Last Deletion to restore the most recently deleted record.
3. The undo button is disabled when there are no deleted records waiting to be restored.

## 10. Managing Profile and Theme Settings

The Profile page stores account information and personal display preferences. It also provides the light or dark mode switch.

**Budget Bridge**

Dashboard

Spending

Income

History

**Profile**

Logout

**Profile** Dark Mode

**Profile Information**

Name: Deming

Username: Deming

Email: user@example.com

[Edit Profile](#) [Change Password](#)

**Account Settings**

Account Type: Standard

Status: Active

Member Since: Member

Figure 12. Profile page in light mode.

### 10.1 View Profile Information

- Name: display name for the account.
- Username: login username.
- Email: account email address.
- Account Type, Status, and Member Since: account metadata shown under Account Settings.

### 10.2 Edit Profile

1. Open the Profile page.
2. Select Edit Profile.
3. Update the Name, Username, or Email fields.
4. Select Save Changes to apply updates, or Cancel to discard them.

The screenshot shows the 'Profile' page in light theme. On the left is a sidebar with 'Budget Bridge' at the top, followed by links for 'Dashboard', 'Spending', 'Income', 'History', and 'Profile' (which is highlighted). At the bottom of the sidebar is a 'Logout' link. The main content area is titled 'Profile' and has a 'Dark Mode' toggle in the top right. It contains two sections: 'Profile Information' with input fields for 'Name' (containing 'Deming'), 'Username' (containing 'Deming'), and 'Email' (containing 'user@example.com'), and 'Account Settings' showing 'Account Type: Standard', 'Status: Active', and 'Member Since: Member'. Below the 'Profile Information' section are 'Save Changes' and 'Cancel' buttons. A green chat bubble icon is in the bottom right corner.

Figure 13. Profile edit mode.

### 10.3 Change Password

Select Change Password to send a password reset email to the account email address. Follow the link in the email to enter and confirm a new password.

### 10.4 Switch Light and Dark Mode

Select Dark Mode on the Profile page to switch the interface to dark mode. In dark mode, select Light Mode to return to the light theme.

The screenshot shows the 'Profile' page in dark mode. The sidebar and main content area are dark. The 'Profile' section has a 'Light Mode' toggle in the top right. The 'Profile Information' section has input fields for 'Name' (containing 'Deming'), 'Username' (containing 'Deming'), and 'Email' (containing 'user@example.com'). Below these fields are 'Edit Profile' and 'Change Password' buttons. The 'Account Settings' section shows 'Account Type: Standard', 'Status: Active', and 'Member Since: Member'. A green chat bubble icon is in the bottom right corner.

Figure 14. Profile page in dark mode.

# 11. Using the Budget Bridge Assistant

Budget Bridge includes a floating AI assistant. The assistant can answer questions about your budget, summarize financial data, and provide quick recommendations based on your current application context and finance records.

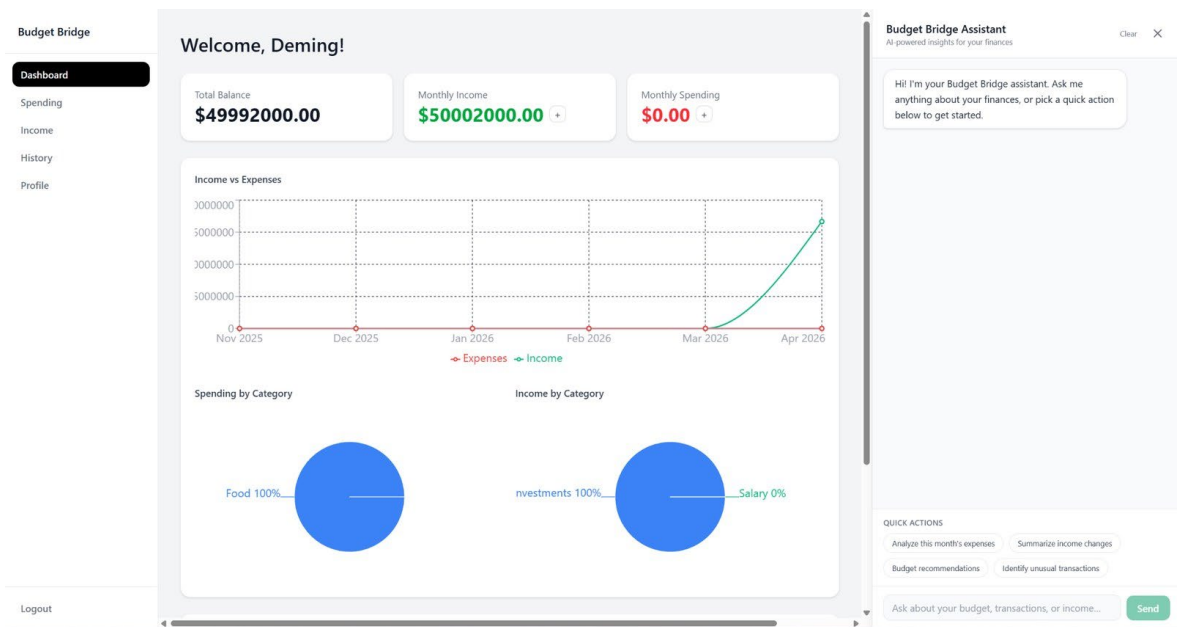


Figure 15. Budget Bridge Assistant panel.

## 11.1 Open and Close the Assistant

1. Select the green chat button in the bottom-right corner.
2. Use the message box to type a question.
3. Press Enter or select Send.
4. Select the X button to close the panel.

## 11.2 Quick Actions

| Quick Action                  | What It Does                                                                          |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Analyze this month's expenses | Breaks down spending by category, highlights major items, and flags unusual patterns. |
| Summarize income changes      | Compares recent income activity across months and categories.                         |
| Budget recommendations        | Suggests practical budget targets based on income, spending, and categories.          |
| Identify unusual transactions | Look for unusually large, duplicate, or unexpected transactions.                      |

## 11.3 Clear a Conversation

Select Clear at the top of the assistant panel to reset the conversation and return to the welcome message.

## 12. Common Tasks

| Task                         | Where to Go                             | Basic Steps                                                                   |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Add an expense               | Spending                                | Select + Add Expense, complete date/category/amount, then select Add Expense. |
| Add income                   | Income                                  | Select + Add Income, complete date/category/amount, then select Add Income.   |
| Find a transaction           | Dashboard, Spending, Income, or History | Use the search box to search for a description or category.                   |
| Show only one category       | Dashboard, Spending, or Income          | Use the All Categories dropdown and select a category.                        |
| Show only income or expenses | History                                 | Use the All Types dropdown.                                                   |
| Sort transactions            | Any transaction table                   | Select a column header such as Date or Amount.                                |
| Delete a transaction         | Spending, Income, or History            | Select Delete on the row.                                                     |
| Undo a deletion              | History                                 | Select Undo Last Deletion.                                                    |
| Change the theme             | Profile                                 | Select Dark Mode or Light Mode.                                               |
| Ask for financial advice     | Assistant                               | Open the chat panel and type a question or choose a quick action.             |

## 13. Glossary

**Budget:** A spending plan that helps allocate income across expenses, savings, and goals.

**Category:** A label used to group income or expenses, such as Food, Salary, or Investments.

**Dashboard:** The main overview page showing balance, trends, charts, and recent transactions.

**Expense:** Money leaving the account, such as purchases, bills, or fees.

**Income:** Money entering the account, such as salary, investment income, or freelance work.

**Monthly Spending:** The total amount of expenses recorded for the current month.

**Net Balance:** Total income minus total expenses.

**Transaction:** A single income or expense record with a date, category, amount, and optional description.

**Trend Chart:** A chart showing how income and expenses change over time.

**AI Assistant:** The Budget Bridge chat panel that provides finance-related summaries and recommendations.